

Brand Attachment and Consumer Emotional Response to Unethical Firm Behavior

Sebastian Schmalz

Kienbaum Executive Consultants International GmbH

Ulrich R. Orth

Christian-Albrechts-University Kiel,
University of South Australia

ABSTRACT

Attaching consumers to a brand is a cornerstone of relationship marketing as attachment increases loyalty. This research investigates another possible benefit of attachment, its potential and limits for shielding brands from firms' ethical missteps. Merging motivated reasoning and attachment theories, two studies focus on how brand attachment influences consumer judgments of firm ethics and the emotional and behavioral consequences developing from those. A field study indicates that attachment attenuates judgments of unethical behavior, contributes to emotional ambivalence, and affects purchase intentions. A subsequent experiment corroborates these findings and shows that the buffering role of attachment is limited to conditions when the information about firm ethics is moderately rather than extremely negative. Implications focus on advancing research on ethics and emotional ambivalence in consumer brand relationships and on managerial implications. © 2012 Wiley Periodicals, Inc.

When *Nokia* announced closing their state-subsidized plant in Germany and moving production to Romania to take advantage of lower labor cost there, emotions ran high with German consumers some of whom turned in their *Nokia* phones. When word got out about *Apple* secretly videotaping employees to reduce theft, even loyal customers expressed irritation and threatened to stop buying iPods, iPhones, or MacBooks. Similarly, when it became public that Chinese suppliers plucked live geese for *Ikea*'s down-beddings, comforters, and pillows, even long-time *Ikea* lovers found themselves in an emotional turmoil between disgust and affection for "their" brand. These examples highlight the relations between consumers receiving information about unethical firm behavior, brand attachment, and affective responses.

Ethics-related research is prevalent in the marketing literature since Hunt and Vitell's (1986) work, and numerous studies advocate that unethical firm behavior increases the likelihood of negative consumer responses (e.g., Creyer & Ross, 1996; Folkes & Kamins, 1999; Joergens, 2006; Whalen, Pitts, & Wong, 1991). Knowledge is limited, however, regarding possible buffering effects emerging from preexisting consumer-brand relationships (Ingram, Skinner, & Taylor, 2005). While consumers penalize unethical firm behavior by refraining from purchasing products

(Shaw, Newholm, & Dickinson, 2006), spreading negative word of mouth (Smith & Cooper-Martin, 1997), retaliating (Bechwati & Morrin, 2003), participating in boycotts (Klein, Smith, & John, 2004; Smith & Cooper-Martin, 1997), or engaging in unethical behaviors of their own (Rosenbaum, Kuntze, & Wooldridge, 2011), gaps remain in knowledge regarding the possible mitigating influence of consumers' attachments to brands, the role of emotions triggered by perceptions of moral violations (Connelly, Helton-Fauth, & Mumford, 2004; Haidt, 2003; Vélez-García & Ostrosky-Solís, 2006), and possible thresholds when the behavior is moderately rather than extremely unethical (Babin, Griffin, & Boles, 2004).

How consumers process negative information about firms and brands has been the focus of previous research. The findings indicate that negative information about a company or its brands leads to negative corporate associations (Einwiller, Fedorikhin, Johnson, & Kamins, 2006), impacts consumer attitudes (Ahluwalia, Burnkrant, & Unnava, 2000; Messner & Reinhard, 2012), and behavioral intentions (Folkes & Kamins, 1999). Negative information about a company can also transfer to consumer judgments about the brands the company markets (Biehal & Sheinin, 2007; Gurhan-Canli & Batra, 2004), an effect established

explicitly for unethical firm behaviors (Folkes & Kamins, 1999). Because negative information receives greater attention and weight relative to positive information (e.g., Klein & Dawar, 2004), and information about unethical behaviors evokes strong, negative emotional responses (Vélez-García & Ostrosky-Solís, 2006), information about a firm behaving unethically will likely elicit negative emotions with consumers. Such negative emotions may negatively influence consumer behavior toward the company's brands and thereby harm sales, profits, and stock price (Einwiller et al., 2006).

However, there are cases in which negative information seems to have little effect on brands. For example, after the previously illustrated unethical behaviors, consumers kept buying *Nokia* phones, *Apple* products, and *Ikea*-ware. These brands seemed to be protected. Their relative immunity to information about unethical behavior may be due to consumers' relationship with the company or the brand. In fact, mitigators of the impact of negative information include consumers' identification with a company (Einwiller et al., 2006; Liu, Wang, & Wu, 2010), product attribute superiority (Folkes & Kamins, 1999), and consumer commitment to a brand (Ahluwalia, Burnkrant, & Unnava, 2000). Most important to the present research, Ahluwalia, Burnkrant, & Unnava (2000) showed that when consumers are highly committed to a brand, they are more likely to dismiss negative *product* information by processing it in a biased manner.

This research builds on and extends previous work in four important ways. First, it shows that the effect of negative information about firm ethics (rather than products) on behavioral intentions is moderated by consumers' emotional attachment to the brand. While it is easy to see that consumers respond strongly to product-related issues (Ahluwalia, Burnkrant, & Unnava, 2000), a growing body of research highlights the importance of examining other aspects of a company's operations including ethical behavior related to staff, suppliers, and the natural environment (Folkes & Kamins, 1999; Ingram, Skinner, & Taylor, 2005; Messner & Reinhard, 2012; Newholm & Shaw, 2007). Corporate actions can create evaluations that encompass products (Brown & Dacin, 1997; Creyer & Ross, 1996; Goldberg & Hartwick, 1990; Sen and Bhattacharya, 2001), but can also transfer to consumers' judgments about the brands the company markets (Biehal & Sheinin, 2007; Duncan & Moriarty, 1998; Gurhan-Canli & Batra, 2004; Sheinin & Biehal, 1999). Folkes and Kamins (1999) persuasively argued that information about firm's actions in the ethical domain is integrated into their evaluation of brands. By focusing on these issues this article broadens the perspective adopted by product publicity researchers.

Second, the present focus is on examining brand attachment rather than brand commitment. Attachment reflects strong self-brand linkages and automatic retrieval of thoughts and feelings about the brand (Park, MacInnis, & Priester, 2006). In contrast, previous re-

search (Ahluwalia, Unnava, & Burnkrant, 2000) focused on commitment, which has been primarily conceptualized in terms of intentions to remain loyal to and hence maintain a relationship with the brand in the future (Ahluwalia, Unnava, & Burnkrant, 2000; Brown, Barry, Dacin, & Gunst, 2005; Warrington & Shim, 2000). Park, MacInnis, and Priester (2006) propose that focusing on attachment is a more valuable objective because commitment is an outcome of attachment (Thomson, 2006), and individuals may be committed to a brand due to lack of competing alternatives or out of some sense of contractual obligation to the company or its sales people. Commitment formed through factors other than attachment may not be associated with strong forms of behavior like investment in the brand; and commitment not based on attachment will not have strong self-brand connections and automatic retrieval of thoughts and feelings about the brand and hence will not predict higher order relationship-based behaviors (Park, MacInnis, & Priester, 2006). By focusing on attachment's role in consumers' formation of ethical judgments, emotional ambivalence, and behavioral intentions, this research provides the greater specificity in the conceptualization of the mechanisms underlying motivational bias that scholars so often called for (e.g., Kruglanski, 1990; Kunda, 1990).

Third is an investigation of the role of consumer emotions, specifically, the role of emotional ambivalence. Most of the literature on motivated judgment does not examine emotions, and the focus on negative emotions only as it is prevalent in ethics research may not be sufficient (Scherer & Tannenbaum, 1986). Emotional processes in ethical decision making are gaining recognition (e.g., Vélez-García & Ostrosky-Solís, 2006), and research into the cognitive bases of affective experiences (e.g., Larsen, McGraw, & Cacioppo, 2001) suggests that consumers who are attached to a brand could experience a dual-valence state, where both positive and negative emotions are felt in response to negative information about firm ethics. Merging research on the affect-regulatory function of attachment (Fuenkeling, 1998; Mikulincer, Hirschberger, Nachmias, & Gillath, 2001; Thomson, 2006) with reports of negative emotional responses to judgments of unethical behavior (Bechwati & Morrin, 2003; Haidt, 2003; Steenhaut & Van Kenhove, 2006; Vélez-García & Ostrosky-Solís, 2006) suggests that attachment and judgments of unethical behavior interact to influence consumer emotional ambivalence.

Fourth, this research demonstrates a boundary condition, which consists in that when a firm behaves extremely negatively brand attachment ceases to buffer effects. Related results indicate that strong identification of consumers with a company can insulate a company from detrimental effects of negative publicity (Liu, Wang, & Wu, 2010) but this buffering effect disappears when the information is extremely negative (Bhattacharya & Sen, 2003; Einwiller et al., 2006). By identifying more extreme unethical firm behavior as a condition under which brand attachment no longer

prevents undesirable consequences, this work blends studies reporting boundary conditions for mitigating effects of consumer–company identification (Bhattacharya & Sen, 2003; Einwiller et al., 2006; Liu, Wang, & Wu, 2010) with suggestions that consumer emotions may play a pivotal role in explaining differential responses to extremely versus moderately unethical behaviors (Babin, Griffin, & Boles, 2004).

The theoretical basis for explaining the immunizing effect of attachment against the impact of moderately unethical behavior, as well as its boundary condition in the case of extremely negative information, is motivated reasoning theory (e.g., Kunda, 1990) also sometimes referred to as “motivated judgment,” “self-serving bias” (Ditto & Lopez, 1992), or “motivational bias” (Kruglanski, 1990). Brand attachment captures the strength of the cognitive and emotional bond connecting the brand with the self (Park, MacInnis, & Priester, 2006). This definition involves two unique and essential elements: (1) connectedness between the brand and the self and (2) a cognitive and emotional bond, the strength of which evokes a readiness to allocate one’s processing resources toward a brand. Attached consumers are motivated to maintain tight and positive bonds with a brand as a means of preserving the brand as a contributor toward their self and to keep their self-concept intact (Mikulincer et al., 2001). If the source of attachment (i.e., the brand) is threatened, the threat extends to the self-concept of those who are attached. Therefore, such a threat can trigger a defensive reaction. When faced with negative information (i.e., on unethical behavior of the brand’s parent firm), attachment can lead to motivated reasoning (e.g., finding excuses) as well as behaviors (e.g., proximity seeking and declarations of loyalty) as defensive reactions (Badcock & Allen, 2003). Park, MacInnis, and Priester (2006) advocate that attachment is a more primary representation of a consumer’s relationship with a brand than commitment and that it is the more fundamental cause of motivated reasoning. Therefore, this research concentrates on the effects of attachment on emotions and behavioral intentions in the context of firm ethics.

This paper posits that consumers who are strongly attached to a brand are likely to be motivated to maintain and protect this bond and to dismiss negative information as much as possible. Less attached consumers, in contrast, are more likely to incorporate information about unethical firm behavior into their judgments, emotional responses, and intentions. Although strong attachment can mitigate the effects of unethical firm behavior (similar to what Ahluwalia, Burnkrant, & Unnava (2000) found for commitment and product-related publicity), this buffering effect should disappear when the information is extremely negative (see Einwiller et al. (2006) for similar effects of consumer–company identification on company associations). However, even strongly attached consumers are not likely to maintain a positive view of a company’s ethical behavior when the information is extremely negative (Babin, Griffin, & Boles, 2004). Consequently, they will exhibit less favor-

able emotional responses and potentially unfavorable behaviors toward the brand, as do those who are less attached. Even strongly attached consumers should reach a point at which “enough is enough” (Einwiller et al., 2006, p. 185), and attachment no longer mitigates the detrimental effects of unethical behavior.

To investigate these issues, the paper proceeds as follows. First, a review of relevant literature leads to a set of hypotheses. Two empirical studies then test these hypotheses: a field study establishes a nomological network for the influence of firm behavior and brand attachment on ethical judgment, emotional ambivalence, and purchase intentions. An experiment then sheds light on interaction effects, examines different product categories with a consumer sample, and demonstrates that the buffering capacity of attachment applies only to moderately unethical behavior. A discussion of the theoretical and managerial implications of the findings concludes the paper.

THEORETICAL BACKGROUND AND HYPOTHESES

Consumers’ Emotional Attachment to Brands

Consumers can become emotionally attached to tangibles and intangibles including brands (Ball & Tasaki, 1992; Lastovicka & Gardner, 1979). Prominent drivers of brand attachments include affective experiences (Orth, Limon, & Rose, 2010), brand characteristics (Robins, Caspi, & Moffitt, 2000), and personal attachment styles (Swaminathan, Stilley, & Ahluwalia, 2009); consequences include brand loyalty and consumers’ willingness to pay a price premium (Thomson, MacInnis, & Park, 2005). Attachment can be very powerful in leading to satisfied, trusting, and committed relationships (Thomson, 2006) and—in brand relationships—commitment and loyalty are two valuable outcomes of attachment (Park, MacInnis, & Priester, 2006). As such, attachment takes a center role in shaping the relations between consumers and brands, and is becoming one of the cornerstones in relationship marketing (e.g., Park & MacInnis, 2006; Paulssen, 2009).

Attachment has further been described as a fundamental human need, leading to an emotion-laden, target-specific relationship between a person and a target (Bowlby, 1979). In a marketing context, this need can motivate consumers to become deeply committed to a brand (Thomson, MacInnis, & Park, 2005). Capturing the strength of the cognitive and emotional bond connecting the brand with the self, attachment not only determines the allocation of processing resources toward a brand (Park, MacInnis, Priester, Eisingerich, & Iacobucci, 2010), but represents strong self-brand connections and automatic retrieval of thoughts and feelings about the brand (Park, MacInnis, & Priester,

2006). Drawing on these characteristics suggests defining attachment as the degree to which consumers feel a sense of connection with a brand and the degree to which aspects of the brand are self-referential and self-defining for them.

Attachments develop and grow over time and are attended by a rich set of schemas that link the target to the self (Baldwin, Keelan, Fehr, Enns, & Koh-Rangarajoo, 1996). If people attach themselves, this attachment encourages the development of meaning and invokes strong positive emotions in reference to the target (Baldwin et al., 1996). As strong brand attachments reflect close ties to the self, consumers are motivated to maintain the emotional bond to keep their self-concept intact (Mikulincer et al., 2001). Therefore, when strongly attached consumers' positive ties to a brand are challenged, for example by negative information, consumers are likely to try and protect those bonds. However, this mitigating effect of attachment should reach its limits when the degree of negativity increases (Babin, Griffin, & Boles, 2004; Einwiller et al., 2006). Specifically, strongly attached consumers should tolerate unethical behavior of a brand's parent firm up to a certain point, through their motivation to keep their self-concept intact (Mikulincer et al., 2001). Yet, if the reported behavior is too unethical, a threshold will be reached beyond which the brand can no longer contribute to the self-concept. Motivated reasoning theory sheds light on the potential effects of attachment on the judgment of ethical firm behavior.

Motivated Reasoning and Ethical Judgments

Cognitively mediated motivations can influence the quality of consumer decision making (Agrawal & Maheswaran, 2005). Some motivations relate to people being concerned with feeling or appearing accurate, whereas others prompt fast decisions and action (Fiske, 1993). Important is the capability of motivations to produce cognitive biases, because they can trigger cognitive processes that lead to desired conclusions (Kunda, 1990). For example, people who are motivated to arrive at a specific conclusion tend to stereotype and to depend more on a biased search (Fiske, 1993). They also search more specifically for information that supports their desired conclusion (Pyszczynski & Greenberg, 1997), and draw the conclusion only if they can assemble enough evidence to support it (e.g., Kronzon & Darley, 1999). In doing so, people think they are objective in their decision making; however, they fail to see that their decision process is skewed because they access only a part of their knowledge (see Kruglanski, 1990). Given a different set of goals on another occasion, they activate different information and convictions, possibly justifying an opposite conclusion. Taken together, the literature on "motivated reasoning" or "motivated judgment" indicates that information consistent with a preferred conclusion is examined less critically than information

inconsistent with a preferred conclusion (Ditto & Lopez, 1992).

At the theoretical level, several researchers have responded to Tetlock and Levi's (1982) call for greater specificity in the conceptualization of the mechanisms underlying motivational bias (Kruglanski, 1990; Kunda, 1990). A major goal for such studies is to move beyond the simple notion that motivation affects judgment by identifying specific points at which motivational processes enter into, and how exactly they alter the consumers' information-processing sequence. A review of the motivational bias literature (Kunda, 1990), however, reveals considerably more empirical support for the basic proposition (motivational factors affect judgment) than direct evidence for exactly how this process occurs.

Marketing researchers have reported motivational bias effects for consumers' evaluation of brands (Posovac, Sanbonmatsu, Kardes, & Fitzsimons, 2004). More importantly, motivational bias effects have also been found regarding ethical judgments (Mullen & Skitka, 2006). When people have strong ethical convictions about outcomes, their judgments become more driven by whether outcomes support or oppose their convictions than by whether procedures are proper or improper (the moral mandate effect). Specifically, people with ethical convictions react with strong emotions (i.e., anger) when outcomes are inconsistent with their point of view, which, in turn, colors perceptions of both outcomes and procedures (Mullen & Skitka, 2006).

Strong attachments should evoke the motivation to protect the emotion-laden bond and the self-concept support derived from a relationship with the brand. Strongly attached consumers should engage in defensive information processing with a bias in the direction of their preferred conclusion (Britton & Fuendeling, 2005). Attachment research, in fact, reports the suppression or discounting of any cue that might threaten the secure base of the attachment system (Mikulincer & Shaver, 2005). For example, if a consumer who is strongly attached to her iPhone were to receive news about Apple, Inc. secretly videotaping employees, she would likely be biased in processing the information such that she can arrive at a positive conclusion (e.g., "Apple probably has its reasons," or "This practice is not as bad as the press makes it sound"). This biased directional processing would shield the existing connection with the brand, since changing those thoughts and feelings would be threatening her self-concept, of which being an iPhone aficionado is an important part.

Weak attachments, in contrast, which do not reflect strong emotion-laden connections between the brand and the self should be guided more by the motivation to form accurate judgments. According to the negativity bias literature (see Skowronski & Carlston, 1987 for a review), people give greater weight to negative rather than positive information, especially when consumers are motivated to arrive at accurate conclusions

(Ahluwalia, 2002). Judgments of a firm's ethical behavior should thus become more unfavorable as the negativity of the information increases (Kellaris, Dahlstrom, & Boyle, 1998). More specifically, consumer judgments of a firm's ethical behavior should show a main effect of attachment, with information perceived as more positive by those who are more attached to the brand:

- H1:** Consumers who are more rather than less attached to a brand will judge parent firm's behavior as less unethical.

Theory and empirical evidence, however, advocate that motivated reasoning has its limits. In building her case for motivated reasoning, Kunda (1990) acknowledged that people motivated to arrive at a particular conclusion still try to be rational and draw the desired conclusion only if they can accumulate enough evidence to support it (Kronzon & Darley, 1999). Given that extremely negative information can be highly diagnostic (Folkes & Kamins, 1999), people may find it hard to ignore even if they would like to do so (Ahluwalia, 2000). In addition people tend to exhibit a "negativity bias" in evaluating moral behaviors in that they weigh negative behaviors more heavily than positive ones (e.g., Skowronski & Carlston, 1987). Rather than merely impacting judgments relative to the negativity of information, information about more and less unethical actions has an asymmetrical influence, such that extreme transgressions impact judgments more than moderate missteps (Reeder & Bruwer, 1979; Skowronski & Carlston, 1987). If a firm's behavior is extremely unethical, people may no longer be able to reduce the weight given to that negative information as a strategy to protect the secure base (Mikulincer & Shaver, 2005). Therefore, while strongly attached consumers may disregard information about a firm's moderately unethical behavior, they may not be able to ignore information about more extremely unethical behavior (Einwiller et al., 2006).

In summary, because of motivated reasoning, consumers who are strongly attached to a brand and receive information about the brand's parent firm should process that information in a biased and defensive fashion. Given previously established boundaries of motivated reasoning, this bias should soften or even disappear when the information is extremely negative. Hence:

- H2:** When given moderately negative information, strongly attached consumers will judge parent firm's behavior as less unethical than consumers who are less strongly attached. When given more extremely negative information, ethical judgments will not vary between more and less attached consumers.

Emotional Ambivalence

Ethics research has been dominated by theories that emphasize the role of reasoning in the moral judgment (Eisenberg, 2000; Haidt, 2001). More recent proposals, however, emphasize the role of emotional processes in ethical decision making (e.g., Vélez-García & Ostrosky-Solís, 2006). This change in perspective is the result of recent work in the fields of philosophy, cognitive psychology, and neurobiology (Anderson, Bechara, Damasio, Tranel, & Damasio, 1999; Haidt, 2001; Rozin, Loewry, Imada, & Haidt, 1999). Based on the findings, it has been suggested that emotions are key drivers of moral behavior (Greene & Haidt, 2002).

Consumer researchers have established that individuals respond to perceived ethical transgressions with emotions (Babin, Griffin, & Boles, 2004; Raju & Rajagopal, 2008). Emotions in response to perceived ethical violations are strong, appear rapidly and automatically (Vélez-García & Ostrosky-Solís, 2006), and include primarily negative components such as contempt, indignation, rage, displeasure, shame, and embarrassment (Haidt, 2003), outrage (Bechwati & Morrin, 2003), or guilt (Steenhaut & Van Kenhove, 2005, 2006). Although the extant investigations into the effects of ethical actions on emotions have undoubtedly been useful in advancing the field, some emotions researchers would argue that the sole focus on negative emotions is overly simplistic. Empirical evidence demonstrates that incidences of unidimensional states, such as pure anger or pure happiness, are actually quite rare. In fact, most people react to everyday life by experiencing blends of emotions (Scherer & Tannenbaum, 1986). Stimuli capable of eliciting mixed emotions include advertisements (Madrigal & Bee, 2005; Williams & Aaker, 2002), movies (Larsen, McGraw, & Cacioppo, 2001), film clips (Hemenover & Schimmack, 2007), and gambling (Larsen, McGraw, Cacioppo, & Mellers, 2004). However, studies on mixed emotions have not examined ethical issues, and have mostly investigated select pairs of opposite valence emotions rather than a more complex blend of positive and negative emotions.

Psychologists have emphatically debated the degree to which individuals can experience conflicting emotions simultaneously (see, Bagozzi, Wong, & Yi, 1999). One perspective suggests that the ability to experience conflicting emotions simultaneously is limited, as positive and negative emotions represent opposite dimensions on a bipolar scale (Green, Salovey, & Truax, 1999). A second perspective argues the opposite, namely that emotional valence is represented by two independent dimensions. Thus, not only can one simultaneously experience conflicting emotions, but such an experience may be natural and frequently occurring (Cacioppo, Gardner, & Berntson, 1997; Larsen, McGraw, & Cacioppo, 2001). Taken together, these literatures suggest two different ways of conceptualizing mixed emotions or emotional ambivalence.

The first conceptualization derives from attitudinal theories, which acknowledge that people can hold simultaneous positive and negative attitudes about a target (e.g., Priester & Petty, 1996; Thompson, Zanna, & Griffin, 1995). Comparing different models for capturing attitudinal ambivalence Priester and Petty (1996) concluded that the similarity-intensity model (SIM: Thompson, Zanna, & Griffin, 1995) which reflects how alike and how strong opposing responses are is one of the best in terms of construct validity. Although the SIM model has been developed in the context of opposing attitudes, the concept has been extended to reflect emotional ambivalence (Fong, 2006; Fong & Tiedens, 2002). In two studies, Fong and colleagues use an adapted SIM model to examine opposing emotions arguing that emotional ambivalence is present when two opposing emotions (such as happiness and sadness) are felt at similarly high levels of intensity, whereas emotional ambivalence would be at its lowest when people experience one but not the other emotional state.

An alternative approach has conceptualized ambivalence as an experience when two states that are usually negatively correlated are less negatively correlated (Cacioppo, Gardner, & Berntson, 1997; Green, Salovey, & Truax, 1999). This concept reflects the notion that two states that are usually conflicting (i.e., negatively correlated) are no longer in conflict (either a 0 correlation or a positive correlation). Viewing ambivalence in correlational terms is especially interesting when considering emotional ambivalence because of the current debate regarding the structure of affect. Some researchers have claimed that positive and negative affect are bipolar or negatively correlated (e.g., Barrett & Russell 1998; Green, Salovey & Truax, 1999; Green et al., 1993; Russell & Carroll, 1999). Other researchers have claimed that positive and negative emotions are independent or uncorrelated (e.g., Tellegen & Watson, 1999). Thus, a concept of emotional ambivalence that captures the correlations between positive and negative affect can shed light on the structure of affect debate (Fong & Tiedens, 2002).

With the notable exception of one study (Babin, Griffin, & Boles, 2004), most of the literature on ethical transgressions does not discuss conflicting emotions, nor does it typically refer to the literature on emotional ambivalence. Yet, research into the cognitive bases of affective experiences suggests that consumers can indeed experience a dual-valence state, where both positive and negative emotions are felt in response to negative information about a firm that markets a brand a consumer is attached to. On the one hand, people attach themselves in order to regulate affect, that is, to generate positive feelings (Baldwin et al., 1996; Fuendeling, 1998; Mikulincer et al., 2001); when the attachment target is highlighted, consumers are thus likely to experience positive affect, a typical response in reference to brands that come with strong attachments (Park, MacInnis, & Priester, 2006; Orth, Limon, & Rose, 2010; Thomson, 2006). On the other hand, individual moral convictions may produce neg-

ative emotional responses to judgments of unethical behavior (Haidt, 2003; Vélez-García & Ostrosky-Solís, 2006). This negative emotional response should be bolstered as motivated reasoning—engaged by strongly attached consumers who reason to keep the secure base of their attachment intact—evokes negative emotions including skepticism (Ditto & Lopez, 1992) and anger (Mullen & Skitka, 2006). Because the self-concept is more emotionally laden than is knowledge about others or objects, emotional responses to threats of one's self-concept are particularly strong (Alden, Mukherjee, & Hoyer, 2000; Garbarino & Edell, 1997). Therefore, strongly attached consumers are likely to experience positive emotions (because of the positive affect associated with the brand they are attached to) but also negative emotions (because of pressures to discount or ignore threats to their self-concept), thus leading to a dual-valence experience or emotional ambivalence. Weakly attached consumers, in contrast, are not likely to experience emotional ambivalence because negative information about the firm's ethical behavior does not threaten a key driver of attachment, the generation of positive affect; they may produce only the negative emotions to judgments of unethical behavior. Hence, attachment and judgments of unethical behavior should interact to influence consumer emotional ambivalence:

- H3:** Emotional ambivalence will be high under conditions of strong attachment and judgments of unethical behavior, and will be low under conditions of weak attachment and judgments of ethical behavior.

Behavioral Intentions

Effects of emotional ambivalence on intentions and behavior follow in the footsteps of informational theories of emotion (see Forgas [2000] for a review). The basic argument of the informational approach is that people use emotions as signals or information regarding the type of environment that they are in. These signals direct them to think and behave in ways that will help them adapt to that specific environment. For example, people interpret negative emotions as a signal that they could be in a dangerous or unsatisfactory situation, and so they react to this signal by engaging in careful and deep information processing (Schwarz, 2002). Similarly, emotional ambivalence is considered to be a bothersome, disharmonious state, and out of line with the typical desire for consistency and clear action tendencies (Cacioppo, Gardner, & Berntson, 1997; Priester and Petty, 1996).

The role of emotions in shaping attitudes and intentions is generally acknowledged (Brown & Stayman, 1992), and previous studies unrelated to ethical issues have demonstrated the significant impact of emotional ambivalence on a variety of consumer responses including buying behavior (e.g., Drolet & Lau-Gesk, 2003; Grasshoff & Williams, 2005; Lau-Gesk, 2005). Because

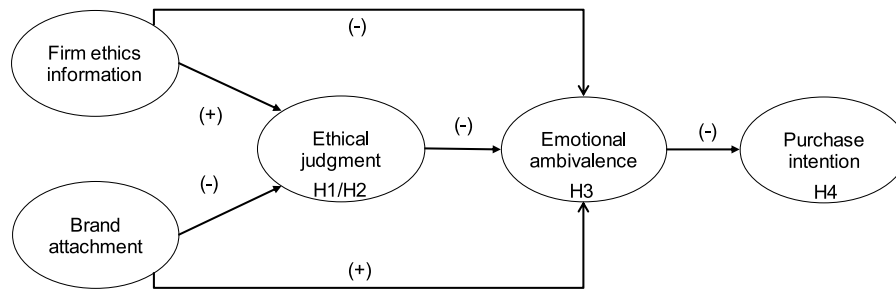


Figure 1. Hypothesized relationships between key constructs.

those studies converge on the finding that higher levels of ambivalence generally relate to less favorable outcomes (e.g., Grasshoff & Williams, 2005; Priester & Petty, 1996; Williams & Aaker, 2002), the differential effects of attachment on ethical judgment through emotional ambivalence should translate into divergent levels of purchase intentions. Extending the previously discussed interactive effects of attachment and judgments of unethical behavior from emotional ambivalence to intentions suggests:

- H4:** Purchase intention will be lower under conditions of strong attachment and judgments of unethical behavior, and will be higher under conditions of weak attachment and judgments of ethical behavior.

Figure 1 summarizes the relationships between key constructs. Two studies test the hypotheses. The first study relies on a survey and descriptions of actual firm behaviors to assess the relations between firm behavior, attachment, ethical judgment, emotional ambivalence, and purchase intentions in a structural equations model (SEM). The second study employs an experiment, to corroborate the relations, and to examine effects for moderately versus extremely negative information about ethical firm behavior.

STUDY 1

Stimuli and Procedure

Study 1 was designed to test how attachment and firm behavior influence ethical judgment, the experience of emotional ambivalence, and purchase intentions. A field study used two real and current descriptions of actual firm behavior. Accessing individual judgments via descriptive scenarios is an established means in ethics research (e.g., Liu, Wang, & Wu, 2010). Considerations for selecting appropriate stimuli included identifying firm behaviors that could plausibly generate varying levels of ethical judgments, and relate to brands with varying levels of consumer attachment (Carroll & Ahuvia, 2006). To reduce the likelihood of demand effects, pretested scenarios ascertained that participants did

not guess the experimental hypotheses correctly. In addition, using a between-subjects design also made demand effects less likely (Shimp, Hyatt and Snyder, 1991). Based on these considerations, and after pretesting alternatives, two firm behaviors emerged each generating large variance in ethical judgments ($M = 4.43$, $s = 1.73$) and attachment ($M = 3.08$, $s = 1.66$). One involved *Nokia* and the other *Media Market* (a national retailer of consumer electronics) (see Appendix A).

Randomly intercepted at various campus locations, 157 students (49.7% females, 24.2 years mean age) completed a self-administered questionnaire. Participants first answered a set of questions assessing their attachments (to both brands) before they proceeded to one randomly selected scenario. After reading the text, respondents submitted ethical judgments, emotions, and purchase intentions, in that order.

Measures

The study employed measures that were all well tested and previously validated. *Attachment* was assessed through Thomson, MacInnis, and Park's (2005) 10-item emotional attachment scale. Respondents described the extent to which items such as "loving," "bonded," or "attached" described their feelings toward the brand on a 7-point scale ranging from 1 = not at all to 7 = very well. Factor analysis indicated that all items strongly (>0.73) loaded on a single factor that explained 68.8% of the original variance ($\alpha = 0.92$).

Ethical judgments were assessed through the multidimensional ethics scale (MES) initially developed by Reidenbach and Robin (1990) and validated through several other studies (e.g., Jones & Middleton, 2007; Loo, 2004). Researchers commonly use the MES to categorize subjects according to their beliefs about the criteria they use to make ethical decisions and to rate the ethicality of those decisions with higher scores indicating more unethical judgments (Shanahan & Hyman, 2003). The scale's seven 7-point semantic differential items (e.g., morally right—morally wrong, acceptable—not acceptable, fair—unfair) strongly (>0.68) loaded on a single factor that explained 72.8% of the original variance ($\alpha = 0.87$). Although the finding of a single factor stands in contrast to the original study (Reidenbach & Robin, 1990), it is in line with follow-on in-depth analyses (Davis, Andersen, & Curtis, 2001).

Participants' *emotions* evoked by the firm behavior's description were assessed on a scale derived from the Standard Emotional Profile (Batra & Holbrook, 1990). In line with study objectives, this scale differentially captures both positive and negative emotions. Respondents indicated their emotional state on 17 feeling items on a 7-point scale from 1 = not at all to 7 = very much. Maximum likelihood factor analysis established the adequacy of the two-factor model. Model fit statistics were satisfactory (χ^2 (136) = 191.69, $p < 0.05$, comparative fit index (CFI) = 0.95, $RMSR$ = 0.06, $RMSEA$ = 0.05), indicating that the structure of the data corresponded with the two-factor model (Hu & Bentler, 1999), with one factor comprised of positive and the other comprised of negative emotion. Both constructs had average variance extracted (AVE) equaling or exceeding 0.74, indicating acceptable convergent validity; composite reliability (CR) measures were also acceptable ($CR > 0.88$). For these reasons, researchers collapsed items into two constructs labeled *negative emotions* (angry, contemptuous, disgusted, distrustful, irritated, revolted, scornful, uneasy, worried) and *positive emotions* (envious, excited, happy, interested, involved, loving, stimulated, wishful).

Creating an emotional *ambivalence* measure relied upon the conceptualization and method discussed in Thompson, Zanna, and Griffin (1995) where ambivalence is characterized by two necessary and sufficient conditions. First, both components must be of at least moderate intensity. Second, the two emotional components must be of similar magnitude, where both positive and negative emotions are felt to the same degree. A simplification of their SIM predicts that ambivalence is a linear function of three times the conflicting reactions minus the dominant reactions. The dominant reaction (D) is determined by the greater absolute value of the either positive or negative reactions and the lesser of the positive or negative reactions is referred to as the conflicting reaction (C). Thus, $Ambivalence = 3C - D$ (Priester & Petty, 1996; $M = 1.53$; $SD = 2.99$). Originally developed to assess attitudinal ambivalence, the measure has been repeatedly validated for emotional ambivalence research (Fong, 2006; Fong & Tiedens, 2002; Madrigal & Bee, 2005; Williams & Aaker, 2002).

Results

The two scenarios generated large variance in ethical judgment ($M = 4.57$, $s = 1.67$) and brand attachment ($M = 2.72$, $s = 1.57$), as intended. No differences in ethical judgment or attachment levels emerged relating to the brands Nokia and Media Market ($p > 0.05$).

Estimating a SEM shed light on the relations among study constructs and addressed the question if and to what extent attachment contributes to consumers' response when it coincides with more or less unethical firm behavior. SEM results indicate a good model fit (χ^2 (121) = 201.26, $p = 0.022$, CFI = 0.93, normative fit index (NFI) = 0.90, $RMSR$ = 0.05, $RMSEA$ = 0.05) with attachment exerting a significant negative influ-

ence on ethical judgment ($b = -0.20$; $t = -2.56$; $p = 0.010$), a positive influence on ambivalence ($b = 0.24$; $t = 3.09$; $p = 0.002$), and a significant positive effect on purchase intention ($b = 0.30$; $t = 4.14$; $p = 0.001$). In addition, firm behavior had a significant negative effect on ethical judgment ($b = -0.16$; $t = -2.12$; $p = 0.034$), which in turn had a significant negative effect on ambivalence ($b = -0.15$; $t = -1.93$; $p = 0.045$), and a significant negative effect on purchase intention ($b = -0.35$; $t = -4.98$; $p = 0.001$). Ambivalence then also had a significant negative effect on purchase intention ($b = -0.16$; $t = -2.08$; $p = 0.040$). These findings provide initial support for the contention that attachment plays a significant role in consumers' response to unethical firm behavior. The significant effect of attachment on ethical judgment supports H1, the joint effects of attachment and firm behavior on ambivalence supports H2, and the significant effect of ambivalence on intentions supports H4.

Accounting for the previously discussed conceptualization of ambivalence suggested further examining positive and negative emotions to continue to shed light on the ambivalent nature of consumers' emotional responses. If the correlation between positive and negative emotions is zero or positive, this finding would present additional evidence for the presence of conflicting or mixed emotions under conditions of divergent attachments and ethical judgments.

To accomplish this goal, a second SEM was estimated which was identical to the first one except for the emotional ambivalence variable which was substituted with one variable each for positive and negative emotions. SEM results indicate a good model fit (χ^2 (128) = 189.15, $p = 0.026$, CFI = 0.96, NFI = 0.94, $RMSR$ = 0.06, $RMSEA$ = 0.05) with relations between attachment, ethical judgment, and purchase intention very similar or identical to the original model. More importantly, the correlation between positive and negative emotions was nonsignificant, indicating nonbipolarity, or independence of positive and negative emotions (Barrett & Russell, 1998). In addition, attachment had a significant positive effect on positive emotions ($b = 0.28$; $t = 3.63$; $p = 0.001$), but no significant ($p > 0.05$) effect on negative emotions; whereas ethical judgment had a significant positive effect on negative emotions ($b = 0.64$; $t = 10.31$; $p = 0.001$), but no significant ($p > 0.05$) effect on positive emotions. Finally, positive emotions had a significant positive effect on purchase intention ($b = 0.21$; $t = 2.88$; $p = 0.009$), whereas negative emotions had a significant negative effect ($b = -0.44$; $t = -6.06$; $p = 0.001$). Therefore, the results present ample support for the ambivalent nature of consumer emotional responses.

Discussion of Study 1 Findings

Study 1 was designed to address the question what—if any—role brand attachment and emotional ambivalence play in consumer response to unethical firm behavior. The findings emphasize the importance of

attachment, ethical judgment, and ambivalent emotions as key constructs, and establish a baseline for experimental manipulations in a subsequent study. Specifically, brand attachment emerged as an important driver of consumer response to unethical firm behavior. Attachment influenced future purchase intentions directly as well as indirectly through ethical judgments and emotional ambivalence.

STUDY 2

While Study 1 established relationships in a field setting, Study 2 aimed more specifically at determining the hypothesized boundary condition of extremely unethical behavior in a controlled setting for a consumer sample and a different set of brands. Study 2 research goals specifically include testing consumer responses to moderately versus more extremely unethical firm behavior (H2), replicating the interactive effect of attachment and ethical judgment on ambivalence (H3), and the detrimental effect of ambivalence on purchase intentions (H4).

Participants and Procedure

Study 2 employed a 2 (attachment: high vs. low) $\times$ 2 (negativity of information about firm ethics: moderate vs. extreme) $\times$ 2 (brands: Coca-Cola vs. McDonalds) between-subjects full-factorial design. A news article was selected as the stimulus object because consumers routinely use articles as a source of information about firm ethics (Humphreys, Robin, Reidenbach, & Moak, 1993). Furthermore, an article offers a convincing test of the impact of firm ethics information on consumer responses because—compared with corporate communications—it is a type of stimulus that consumers use and appreciate with a higher degree of confidence in the credibility of content (Yoon & Gurhan-Canli, 2003).

For the brand attachment manipulation, an extensive pilot identified strong brands known to polarize consumers (i.e., splitting them into either loyal supporters or strong opponents). In hedonic categories (Carroll & Ahuvia, 2006), 20 consumers listed brands they felt strongly attached to and knew that others were not at all attached to. In the end, Coca-Cola and McDonalds emerged as either having strongly attached or weakly attached consumers. During the main study, participants were screened for their attachments, and assigned into either the strong or weak attachment condition.

Information about the firm's ethical behavior was manipulated as moderately versus more extremely negative (Jones, 1991) by keeping the particular type of behavior (ethics) constant but varying the type of compensation offered by the company for the ethical misstep (see, Folkes & Kamins, 1999). The behaviors were all portrayed as intentional policies and as occurring inside

the country. Creating new jobs (paying higher wages) in exchange for ethical misbehavior was intended to indicate moderately negative information; whereas behaving unethically without creating new jobs (paying lower wages) was intended to indicate more extremely negative information. Researchers selected negatively impacting the natural environment (mistreating employees) as types of behavior because the study population (in Germany) perceived both as unethical (Bardy & Rubens, 2010). An initial set of 19 scenarios relied on actual newspaper articles about cases of ethically questionable firm behavior. A pretest ascertained that consumers perceived the descriptions as plausible and the information contained as moderately or extremely negative. The two brands and two scenarios selected for the main study qualified because each of them generated large variance in ethical judgment and attachment (see Appendix B).

Using a random intercept procedure in a major city in Northern Germany generated a sample of 240 consumers ($M_{\text{age}} = 33.43$ years, 53.8% females). Each participant responded to a randomly assigned single scenario varying in levels of attachment, firm behavior, and brand. Contingent upon their answers in the attachment scenario, respondents were assigned to either the high or low attachment condition. Consumers who could not identify with either condition were presented with the second brand and given the same choices. A few consumers who indicated not being attached either high or low to one of the two brands were dismissed from the study. After establishing brand and attachment levels, interviewers randomly assigned respondents to either the moderate or unethical scenario and handed over the questionnaire.

After submitting their attachment and reviewing the scenario, respondents first indicated their ethical judgment. Next they expressed their emotions and purchase intention. Finally, they completed confound checks and demographic questions. After returning the questionnaire, respondents were debriefed and told that the scenario was fictitious and developed exclusively for academic purposes.

Measures

Measures employed in Study 2 were identical to the ones used in Study 1. For the confound check, participants indicated their level of agreement with two statements concerning the credibility of the article. They indicated the degree to which the information they read about the firm behavior was credible on a scale anchored by "not credible at all" and "very credible" (Meyer, 1988). To reduce the likelihood of demand effects, a separate question assessed whether participants could guess the experimental hypotheses. Responses indicated that participants did not guess the purpose of this research correctly. Table 1 holds summary statistics for Study 2 constructs.

Table 1. Summary Statistics and Reliabilities for Study 2 Constructs.

Variable	No. of Items	Variance Explained (%)	<i>M</i>	SD	α
Attachment	3	79.18	1.77	0.95	0.86
Ethical judgment	7	78.22	4.38	1.47	0.93
Ambivalence*	2	-	5.64	4.87	-
Positive emotions	8	32.40	2.17	1.39	0.93
Negative emotions	9	43.54	3.15	1.69	0.96
Purchase intentions	1	-	4.90	1.98	-
Credibility	1	-	3.40	1.57	-

*Confirmatory factor analysis: $\chi^2(136) = 168.77$, $p < 0.05$, $CFI = 0.96$, $RMSR = 0.05$, $RMSEA = 0.05$.

Results

Manipulation Checks. A series of ANOVAs checked the effectiveness of experimental manipulations. Results indicate a significant effect of the attachment manipulation on measured attachment ($F(1, 238) = 318.51$, $p = 0.001$), and a significant effect of the negative information about firm ethics on ethical judgment ($F(1, 238) = 7.21$, $p = 0.008$) with consumers being more or less attached ($M = 1.00$ vs. $M = 2.43$), and with extremely negative information being evaluated as more unethical than the moderately negative information scenarios ($M = 4.63$ vs. $M = 4.13$, respectively). The effect of the brand on ethical judgment was not significant ($F(1, 238) = 0.09$, $p = 0.767$), nor was the effect of the brand on credibility ($F(1, 238) = 1.72$, $p = 0.191$), or the information negativity effect on credibility ($F(1, 238) = 0.06$, $p = 0.813$). These results indicate that the experimental manipulations were successful.

ANOVA results further indicate that attachment had no main effect on ethical judgment ($F(1, 238) = 0.97$, $p = 0.325$). Given that both attachment and ethical judgment were manipulated rather than measured, this result does not contradict the support for H1 generated through Study 1.

Results. H2 predicts that there are limits to motivated reasoning, and that ethical judgments will vary between more and less attached consumers when the information provided is moderately negative but not when it is extremely negative. In support of this hypothesis, there was a significant interaction effect between attachment and the negativity of information ($F(3, 236) = 5.89$, $p = 0.010$). Strong attachment to the brand was associated with judgments of less unethical behavior in the face of moderately negative information ($M = 3.91$ vs. $M = 4.36$), but not when that information was more extremely negative ($M = 4.58$ vs. $M = 4.65$).

H3 predicts that attachment and ethical judgment will interact to influence emotional ambivalence. Attachment had a significant main effect on ambivalence ($F(1, 238) = 4.19$, $p = 0.042$). Importantly, the Attachment $\times$ Ethical behavior interaction was also signif-

icant ($F(3, 236) = 3.75$, $p = 0.048$) with ambivalence high under conditions of high attachment and unethical behavior ($M = 6.80$), low under conditions of low attachment and moderately unethical behavior ($M = 4.32$), and moderate under conditions of high attachment and moderately unethical behavior and low attachment and unethical behavior ($M = 5.61$ and $M = 5.78$, respectively). These findings support H3.

Examining the correlations between positive and negative emotions under varying conditions of high versus low attachment and ethical judgment further corroborates the presence of ambivalent emotions. Specifically, ratings of positive and negative emotions were significantly negatively correlated for consumers who judged firm behavior as moderately unethical ($r = -0.24$, $p = 0.006$), but were not correlated for consumers who judged firm behavior as extremely unethical ($r = 0.10$, $p = 0.267$). A comparison of these two correlation terms showed that they are significantly different ($Z = 3.19$, $p < 0.01$). Because it is the interaction between attachment and ethical judgment that is expected to evoke emotional ambivalence rather than attachment or ethical judgment alone, further examinations focused on correlations between positive and negative emotions under varying conditions of attachment and ethical judgment. Results indicate that the nonsignificant correlation observed when attachment is high and the firm behavior is judged as moderately unethical ($r = 0.21$, $p = 0.076$) is significantly different ($p > 0.05$) from the correlation terms obtained under conditions of low attachment and moderately unethical behavior ($r = 0.43$, $p = 0.001$), low attachment, and extremely unethical behavior ($r = -0.01$, $p = 0.910$), or high attachment and extremely unethical behavior ($r = -0.20$, $p = 0.131$). These findings further support H3.

H4 predicts that effects of attachment and the negativity of unethical behavior will extend to purchase intentions. As expected, attachment had a significant main effect on purchase intentions ($F(1, 238) = 26.27$, $p = 0.001$), and the negativity of firm ethics (technically a covariate) had a significant main effect ($F(1, 238) = 10.82$, $p = 0.001$). The Attachment $\times$ Information negativity interaction effect was significant ($F(2, 237) = 5.28$, $p = 0.014$) with purchase intentions high under conditions of high attachment and moderately unethical behavior ($M = 5.84$), lower under conditions of low attachment and moderately unethical behavior ($M = 5.17$), and lowest under conditions of extremely unethical behavior for both high attachment ($M = 4.31$) and low attachment ($M = 4.12$). These findings support H4.

Discussion of Study 2 Findings

Study 2 results highlight the importance of brand attachment as it attenuates negative effects of unethical firm behavior on emotional ambivalence and purchase intentions. This capacity is limited, however, as more extremely negative information leads strongly attached

consumers to respond similarly to less attached consumers in terms of judgment and intention. The results further underscore the role of emotional ambivalence as a central response to firm ethics with a consumer sample and real brands.

GENERAL DISCUSSION

Advancement of Theory

Generally speaking, the present work extends ethics research by elaborating on the consumer–brand relationship perspective. More specifically, it examines the roles of brand attachment as an important determinant of consumer responses to firm ethics, and of emotional ambivalence as a consequence with downstream effects extending onto behavioral intentions. A boundary condition is established as strongly attached consumers respond as negatively as do weakly attached consumers when the news about firm ethics is extremely negative.

The finding that brand attachment biases judgments of firm ethics extends research on negative publicity, which typically centered on product-related aspects of a company's operation. While it is easy to see that consumers respond strongly to product-related issues (e.g., Ahluwalia, Burnkrant, & Unnava, 2000), establishing that close consumer–brand relationships protect a firm also against ethical missteps broadens the perspective adopted by product publicity researchers. This was not necessarily to be expected as people may weigh their moral convictions differently than their concern for product quality (Chatzidakis, Hibbert, & Smith, 2006). Showing that the buffering effect of strong consumer–brand relationships extends from product- to company-related issues adds to the body of research on the diagnosticity of information (Skowronski & Carlston, 1987) by underscoring the complexities in the way firm ethics information influences consumer evaluations of brands (Folkes & Kamins, 1999).

The present research further extends studies establishing the role of commitment (e.g., Ahluwalia, Burnkrant, & Unnava, 2000) by showing that brand attachment attenuates effects of negative information. Identifying attachment, an antecedent of commitment (Park, MacInnis, & Priester, 2006; Thomson, 2006), as a specific moderator of the generic information-processing sequence, heeds calls for greater specificity in the conceptualization of the mechanisms underlying motivational bias (Kruglanski, 1990; Kunda, 1990; Tetlock & Levi, 1982). The result advocates that it is the strength of the cognitive and emotional bond between the brand with the self (i.e., attachment [Park, MacInnis & Priester, 2006]) and not other factors captured by the commitment construct (e.g., a lack of alternatives or a sense of contractual obligation) that motivates consumers to bias judgments and experience ambivalent emotions.

Relating ambivalence to judgments of unethical firm behavior merges research on business ethics and consumer emotions. While previous studies suggested that consumer emotional responses should primarily be negative (e.g., Haidt, 2003), the present findings show that negative emotions may be accompanied by positive emotions as a result of consumer attachment to the brand. Extending previous findings that high levels of opposite discrete emotions result in less favorable outcomes (Grasshoff & Williams, 2005; Williams & Aaker, 2002), the present research shows that more complex blends of mixed emotions lead to undesirable outcomes for marketers.

Finally, the second study presented here examines moderately rather than extremely unethical firm behavior. Scholars have dedicated much effort to investigating responses to extremely unethical conduct, which elicited little doubt and resulted in extreme behavioral consequences including boycott (e.g., Bechwati & Morrin, 2003; Klein, Smith, & John, 2004). Focusing on moderately unethical behavior with the potential to trigger larger variance and more subtle consumer responses broadens the field of business ethics, especially when customer retention is the goal. Research findings suggest that consumers' capacity to suppress or discount extremely negative information is not unlimited. That is, when the news is extremely negative the strongly attached judge firm ethics as negatively as do the weakly attached. This finding is consistent with research in corporate PR showing that favored companies fall from consumer grace when the perceived performance falls significantly below inflated expectations (Einwiller et al., 2006). Apparently, the negativity of information reaches a point where people find it hard to ignore (Ahluwalia, 2000), and are unwilling or unable to further reduce the information's weight to protect their secure base (Mikulincer & Shaver, 2005).

Managerial Implications

Several important managerial implications emerge from the research presented here. The findings suggest that a firm can pursue a proactive strategy to protect itself from the impact of negative information about ethical issues as long as the negativity of the news is not too extreme. Specifically, focusing on strongly attaching consumers to the firm's brand(s) may aid in buffering the impact of moderately negative information. However, managers should realize that the attenuating effect of strong brand attachments has its limits when the negativity of information becomes too extreme.

Promising strategies to build strong attachments set out from the recognition that consumer–brand relationships involve reciprocal exchanges between active and interdependent partners, the provision of meaning which can vary and range across several dimensions, and the fact that attachments evolve and change over a series of interactions and in response to fluctuations in the environment (Fournier, 1998). Previous research

has demonstrated various ways of how firms can more strongly attach consumers to their brands including cultivating social networks and a sense of community (McAlexander, Schouten, & Koenig, 2002), enhancing consumer feelings of autonomy and relatedness without suppressing feelings of competence (Thomson, 2006), providing strong and positively valenced affective experiences (Brakus, Schmitt, & Zarantonello, 2009), creating strong, favorable, and unique brand associations (Swaminathan, Stilley, & Ahluwalia 2009), and offering more symbolic benefits, especially in hedonic categories (Carroll & Ahuvia, 2006). The present studies showed that pursuing strong attachment can serve as a viable concept to justify investments into consumer–brand relationships, if the firm seeks protection against ethical missteps. Taken together, building strong relationships between consumers and brands has important implications beyond increasing customer loyalty; it helps to buffer possible negative effects in the event of accidental unethical firm behavior.

Limitations and Future Research

Although this work offers important insights, some limitations should be mentioned. Shortcomings start with the fact that this research focused on a variety of stakeholder groups as objects of firm ethics. The scenarios characterized Nokia and McDonald's as treating their employees unethically, whereas Media-Market scenarios portrayed customers, and the Coca-Cola scenario detailed ethical missteps related to the natural environment. It cannot be excluded that the subjects of unethical behavior along with consumers' attitudes toward those may have an additional impact on consumer response to firm ethics. For example, environmentally conscious consumers may respond more negatively to firms mistreating the natural environment, altruistic consumers to unethical firm behavior related to people, and a third group of consumers when animals are concerned (Newholm & Shaw, 2007). Future studies could thus examine the role of individual differences and behavioral targets in influencing ethical judgments, emotions, and downstream constructs to further improve our understanding of business ethics and relationship issues.

Another possible extension of this research relates to the consequences for attachment when it is called upon to buffer against consequences of transgressions. People feel guilty when choosing an unethical alternative (Hunt & Vitell, 1986), or when they perceive violations of moral principles (Steenhaut & Van Kenhove, 2006). When experiencing guilt, individuals recognize they have violated moral standards, and are motivated to engage in curative action (e.g., Dahl, Honea, & Manchanda, 2005). This desire to eliminate or at least attenuate the source of guilt may reduce attachment. Future studies could examine this suggestion and test if attachment suffers in the process of buffering against unethical behavior due to the emotion of guilt.

Lastly, the present research adopts a slice-in-time perspective by investigating the impact of negative information about firm ethics on instantaneous consumer responses. This perspective does not account for possible effects of time. Research on intertemporal choice suggests such an influence of time as people tend to overvalue information in the short term and systematically discount or undervalue information in the long term (e.g., Ebert & Prelec, 2006). Applying the underlying principle of hyperbolic discounting to the context of firm ethics would imply that effects are stronger (i.e., transgressions are viewed more negatively) just after the information is received, but then fade as the memory of the transgression, or simply the timing of its occurrence, moves farther into the past. Future studies could address this issue by assessing the role of time, for example, through manipulations of the time elapsed between receipt of the information, and measurement of consumer responses.

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Correspondence regarding this article should be sent to: Ulrich R. Orth, A&F Marketing—Consumer Psychology, Christian-Albrechts-Universität Kiel, Wilhelm-Seelig-Platz 6/7, 24098 Kiel, Germany (uorth@ae.uni-kiel.de).

APPENDIX A STUDY 1 FIRM BEHAVIOR DESCRIPTIONS

Nokia

Despite large annual profits in the local market (134 million € in 2008), the world's largest cell phone manufacturer has announced closing its plant in Bochum, Germany, relocating production to Romania, where construction of a new plant is close to finish. By relocating its plant, *Nokia* will eliminate 2300 existing jobs in Germany and instead create 3500 new jobs in Romania.

Media Market

Germany's leading retailer of consumer electronics celebrates new store openings by offering very limited supplies at extremely low prices to stimulate demand. Hours before the actual opening, consumers fight for the best positions; several were injured in the ensuing

rush and had to be taken to the hospital once the doors were finally opened. Despite complaints of consumer advocacy groups, *Media Market* does not change this policy.

APPENDIX B STUDY 2 SCENARIOS

Generic Section Coca-Cola

Coca-Cola has announced intentions to build a new plant. Space for the new plant will be allocated from a local nature reserve. While the German Society for Nature Conservation (NABU) has voiced strong concern about likely damage to the breeding grounds of red-listed white stork, *Coca-Cola* emphasizes that it will bring 2000 new jobs to the economically underdeveloped region.

Moderate Scenario. To assuage project opponents, *Coca-Cola* states that even more jobs will be created in the near future through a projected increase in the plant's output over the next years.

Unethical Scenario. Opponents of the project argue that the net job creation will be zero as *Coca-Cola* merely shifts production from one region to another.

Generic Section McDonald's

Employees of *McDonald's* regularly complain about working conditions. The fast-food chain has been accused of systematically assigning under-qualified employees (who are particularly reliant on their job) to unattractive night and weekend shifts. Store managers are instructed to not account for family issues.

Moderate Scenario. Responding to those accusations, *McDonald's* stresses that the firm compensates employees by paying higher hourly wages than competitors (i.e., \$13.00/h vs. \$9.50/h).

Unethical Scenario. Heating up the discussion is the recent disclosure that *McDonald's* pays lower hourly wages than competitors (i.e., \$9.50/h vs. \$13.00/h).